Praise of the Three Bodies

Kāyatrayastotra · Toh 1123 · Derge Tengyur

སྐུ་གསུམ་ལ་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise of the Three Bodies, known in Sanskrit as the Kāyatrayastotra and in Tibetan as Kusum la Töpa, is a brief hymn of four verses honoring the three bodies of the buddhas. After an opening homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī, it praises in turn the truth body (dharmakāya), which is neither one nor many, neither an entity nor a nonentity, and is known through each one's own direct awareness; the enjoyment body (saṃbhogakāya), which displays its splendor amid the assembly to delight the wise and spreads the voice of the Dharma through all worlds; and the emanation body (nirmāṇakāya), which appears in many forms throughout the ten directions to ripen beings and dispel the fears of existence. It closes by dedicating the virtue of this homage, wishing to attain the three bodies and to lead all beings onto the path of awakening. Its colophon attributes it to the master Nāgārjuna and records its translation into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Kṛṣṇa Paṇḍita and the translator Tsultrim Gyalwa, and it is Toh 1123 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra).

In the language of India: kāyatrayastotranāma
In the language of Tibet: Praise of the Three Bodies

Homage to the noble Mañjuśrī in youthful form.

Neither one nor many, the basis of the great excellence of benefit for oneself and others,
Neither an entity nor a nonentity, of a single taste like space, whose intrinsic nature is hard to realize,
Untainted, unchanging, peaceful, equal to the unequaled, all-pervading, and free of elaboration:
To that incomparable truth body (dharmakāya) of the Victors, known through individual self-awareness, I pay homage.

Its own splendor, transcending the world and inconceivable, the fruit of a hundred good deeds,
It displays in manifold and vast ways in the midst of the assembly, to bring joy to the wise,
And it ever makes the vast voice of the sacred Dharma spread through all the worlds:
To that enjoyment body (saṃbhogakāya) of the buddhas, abiding in the

kingdom of the Dharma, I pay homage.

To ripen sentient beings, in some places it appears like a blazing fire,
And in others it appears in perfect awakening, the wheel of Dharma, and utter peace;
Engaging in many kinds of varied skillful means, it dispels the fears of the three realms of existence:
To that emanation body (nirmāṇakāya) of the Sages, of great benefit, pervading the ten directions, I pay homage.

To the three bodies of the Sugatas, which ever act solely for the benefit of sentient beings,
Which are born of great, immeasurable merit and wisdom, and utterly transcend the path of mind and word,
I have bowed with faith. By whatever virtue I have thereby gathered, a seed of awakening,
May I attain the three bodies and surely lead all these beings, without exception, onto the path of awakening.

This completes the Praise of the Three Bodies, composed by the master, the noble Nāgārjuna.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Kṛṣṇa Paṇḍita and the translator, the monk Tsultrim Gyalwa.

Translator's Notes

• "Known through individual self-awareness" renders so so rang rig (Skt. pratyātmavedya): the truth body is known only in each one's own direct realization, not through concepts or words. In the third verse, "perfect awakening, the wheel of Dharma, and utter peace" are the principal deeds the emanation body displays: attaining full awakening, turning the wheel of the Dharma, and passing into final nirvāṇa.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.